By all accounts Bhagat Singh was proud of his atheism. He did not wish to be redeemed by God. He had no belief in a paradise or an after-life. Whereas, '[a] God-believing Hindu might be expecting to be reborn a King, a Muslim or a Christian might dream of the luxuries to be enjoyed in Paradise as the reward he is to get for his suffering and sacrifices', the question for Bhagat Singh was, 'But, what am I to expect? I know the moment the rope is fitted round my neck and rafters removed from under my feet, that will be the final moment – that will be the last moment.' He did not believe that his soul would have the luxury of transmigration because, 'I, or to be more precise, my soul as interpreted in the metaphysical terminology shall be finished there', and there is to be '[n]othing further'. He had no regrets about this, no melancholy moments for him to indulge in because:

> A short life of struggle with no such magnificent end, shall in itself be the reward, if I have the courage to take it in that light. That is all. With no selfish motive or desire to be rewarded here or hereafter, quite disinterestedly, have I devoted my life to the cause of independence, because I could not do otherwise.[9]

This is not to say that Bhagat Singh is unaware of the solace of religion or of its psychological benefits for a condemned man who knows he is living on borrowed time on this earth because, 'I know in the present circumstances my faith in God would have made my life easier, my burden lighter, and my disbelief in Him has turned all the circumstances too dry, and the situation may assume too harsh a shape.' He is aware that '[a] little bit of mysticism can make it poetical. But I do not want the help of any intoxication to meet my fate. I am a realist'.[10] What a thundering dissent of religion! And what erudite defiance. No wonder that Shiv Verma, who was in jail with Bhagat Singh, wrote that he had personally witnessed Baba Randhir Singh's attempt to convince Bhagat Singh about the existence of God 'but failed'. As Bhagat Singh himself wrote in his essay, this was 'because reason is the guiding star of my life'. In fact, 'any man who stands for progress has to criticise, disbelieve and challenge every item of the old faith'.[11] He ended by leaving no doubt that even in his last hour he would